Large Language Models for Bayesian Network Parameterization in Software Engineering: Direct Elicitation versus Ranked Nodes

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Abstract

Software engineering (SE) decision makers need models they can understand and use when data are scarce. Bayesian networks (BNs) make probabilistic relationships explicit and incorporate expert knowledge, but eliciting their conditional probability tables (CPTs) is costly. The Ranked Nodes Method (RNM) generates ordinal CPTs from fewer judgments. Should large language models (LLMs) fill complete CPTs or supply fewer judgments to RNM? We compared complete CPTs for 61 ordinal conditional nodes from seven SE BNs in an exploratory study. We tested structured prompts that clarified conditioning, framed probabilities as hypothetical frequencies, and requested consistency checks. Qualitative retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) supplied short passages on domain relationships, without reference probabilities or numerical parameters. Eight conditions used GPT-6 Astra at medium effort across five replications. With equal node weights, total variation averaged 0.2317 for direct elicitation and 0.2404 for RNM, a 3.76% increase. Because nodes were unevenly distributed across five source studies, we weighted each study equally; direct elicitation still had lower error. Both contrasts passed Holm-adjusted paired t-tests, but not exact sign tests. RNM improved 31 nodes, yet larger deteriorations elsewhere outweighed those gains. Structured prompting modestly helped direct elicitation under node weighting; qualitative RAG demonstrated no benefit. RNM requested 40.1% fewer distributions and used 12.1% fewer output tokens, but only 0.61% fewer total tokens. The findings favor direct elicitation as the average numerical baseline in this sample and show why reduced elicitation alone cannot establish a better, cheaper to complete CPT.

CCS Concepts

• **Computing methodologies** → **Bayesian networks**; • **Software and its engineering** → *Software creation and management*.

Keywords

Bayesian networks, large language models, probability elicitation, ranked nodes, software engineering

1 Introduction

Supporting software engineering (SE) decisions faces two main challenges: explaining the basis for a recommendation and obtaining enough relevant data to build a model experts can rely on. Examples include release readiness, quality assessment, and process improvement, where decision makers must judge whether a recommendation's assumptions apply. A review of 108 studies documents the demand for explainability across 23 SE tasks [3]. Training data for machine learning and deep learning may also be scarce, particularly for managerial SE decisions [23]. Explicit assumptions and domain knowledge are therefore valuable.

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Bayesian networks (BNs) offer such an approach. A BN makes relationships and uncertainty explicit in a graph and probabilities, incorporating domain knowledge when data are limited [10, 11]. BNs have supported many SE problems, including early defect prediction [10], effort estimation [17], and diagnosis of development-process problems [21]. A systematic mapping of 106 studies identifies software management and quality as prominent application areas [24]. Building a credible BN nevertheless requires substantial knowledge engineering effort.

Constructing conditional probability tables (CPTs) is a major part of that effort. Each row describes a child's probabilities for one combination of its parents' states; adding parents rapidly increases the number of judgments required [11]. Semi-automatic methods reduce this burden by reconstructing a table from fewer expert judgments or parameters. These include the Ranked Nodes Method (RNM) [11], the Weighted Sum Algorithm (WSA) [20], Analytic Hierarchy Process (AHP)-based pairwise comparisons [5], and interpolation methods [1, 2]. Their assumptions can, however, limit fidelity to the intended probabilities [2].

Large language models (LLMs) are now being explored for CPT construction. Nafar et al. elicited numerical BN parameters directly [18]; Gottal and Matthes reconstructed CPTs from statistical summaries extracted from scientific literature [12]; and Cypko et al. used retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) to support expert BN modeling [6]. Should an LLM specify every row, or supply fewer judgments for a semi-automatic method to complete? Any benefit depends on both the judgments and the reconstruction.

We investigated this question using RNM, which applies to variables with ordered states such as Low, Medium, and High [11, 15]. Instead of requesting the entire CPT, we asked the LLM for distributions at selected parent-state combinations, called *anchors*, and for a rule describing how the parents combine. A numerical fitting procedure then adjusted that rule's weights and uncertainty to match the elicited distributions and generated the complete CPT. We compared this approach with direct complete-table elicitation on 61 ordinal conditional nodes from seven SE BNs.

We also examined support for elicitation. Structured prompts made conditioning explicit and asked for probability and consistency checks; qualitative RAG supplied short passages explaining relevant domain relationships. Crossing the two elicitation methods, two prompt designs, and presence or absence of RAG produced eight conditions. We repeated each five times using GPT-6 Astra at medium effort. This study addresses three research questions:

- **RQ1—Reference agreement:** How does LLM-assisted RNM compare with direct elicitation in complete-CPT agreement across the full SE sample?
- **RQ2—Elicitation support:** How do structured prompting and qualitative RAG affect each method's agreement across complete tables?

- **RQ3—Accuracy and effort:** How does RNM trade reference agreement against requested judgments and observed computational effort?

All three RQs include all 61 nodes and every CPT row, including anchors. The seven BNs cover Scrum process assessment [19], Chrome code review [14], ERP data quality [13], software maintenance logs [8], and software strategic indicators [16]. We give nodes equal weight for the main comparison. Because BNs contribute unequal numbers of nodes, we also weight their five source studies equally and report each BN separately. This evaluates the complete tables available for use rather than restricting attention to configurations omitted from RNM prompts.

Section 2 positions the study in related work, Section 3 describes the experiment, and Section 4 reports the results. Section 5 discusses the RQs and implications for SE, Section 6 examines validity threats, and Section 7 concludes the paper.

2 Background and Related Work

This section explains RNM and briefly introduces alternative CPT construction techniques (Section 2.1), then examines LLM approaches for CPT construction and positions our contributions (Section 2.2).

2.1 Ranked Nodes Method

RNM generates CPTs for ordinal variables such as Low, Medium, and High from a compact description of parent influence and uncertainty [11, 15]. Ordered states correspond to intervals on a common $[0, 1]$ scale. For example, three equally spaced states occupy successive thirds of that scale. For each parent-state configuration, a weighted function combines values from the corresponding parent intervals. A normal distribution, truncated to $[0, 1]$ and centered at the function value before truncation, assigns probability mass to the child's state intervals. Averaging over parent values produces the CPT row.

The function, weights, and variance express different judgments. A weighted mean allows stronger parents to compensate for weaker ones; weighted-minimum and weighted-maximum functions emphasize weaker or stronger parent values. Weights adjust parent influence, while variance controls dispersion across child states. Thus experts specify a relationship and uncertainty rather than independently assessing every row. Parameters can also be fitted to selected elicited distributions, as in our study. The same settings generate all rows, reducing elicitation but restricting the relationships representable. Laitila and Virtanen show that RNM can approximate many CPT relationships while remaining sensitive to parameter choices [15].

RNM is one of several semi-automatic approaches. WSA combines elicited distributions through weighted sums [20]; AHP uses pairwise comparisons [5]; interpolation methods, including InterBeta, infer unassessed distributions from selected inputs [1, 2]. These alternatives use different judgments and assumptions, so reduced elicitation alone does not establish numerical fidelity.

2.2 LLMs for CPT construction

LLM approaches differ in elicitation granularity and supplied evidence. Nafar et al. found that requesting one child-state probability at a time lowered median BN KL divergence for seven of eight models, with more queries [18]. Their FullDist baseline requests one conditional row; ours requests the whole CPT. Their result leaves open whether eliciting fewer configurations and reconstructing the rest improves agreement. Gottal and Matthes reconstruct from numerical summaries [12], which constrain probabilities more directly than qualitative RAG. Rahul and Chowdhury's persona-panel preprint evaluates effort and internal consistency, without independent reference-CPT accuracy [22].

Other work evaluates modeling or predictive support. BIRD illustrates neural–symbolic integration [7] through LLM judgments, constrained fitting, and BN inference [9]. Clinical RAG assists BN modelers [6]; AutoElicit evaluates prediction after updating elicited parameter priors [4]. These outcomes complement numerical CPT agreement but cannot establish it.

We connect these research directions by comparing direct elicitation with LLM anchors plus RNM fitting across complete CPTs for 61 nodes from seven SE BNs. We examine structured prompting, qualitative RAG, and token usage, with anchor diagnostics separating elicitation from fitting. Experimental fits use LLM judgments without reference access. Table 1 compares the studies by supplied evidence, evaluation endpoint, and scope.

3 Method

We crossed direct versus RNM elicitation, baseline versus structured prompting, and absence versus presence of qualitative RAG. Each of the eight conditions covered 61 nodes in five replications ($61 \times 8 \times 5 = 2{,}440$ trials). We compared complete outputs against hidden reference CPTs (RQ1), assessed prompting and evidence effects (RQ2), and measured elicitation and token usage (RQ3).

3.1 BNs and reference CPTs

The sample contains seven BNs from five published SE studies (Table 2). Scrum assesses team and process factors affecting sprint and backlog quality. Chrome 40 and 42 concern code review and post-release defects in two software versions. APS concerns ERP data quality for advanced planning and scheduling; the two software-log BNs concern maintenance logs; SESSI concerns software strategic indicators. Versions from the same study form one publication family.

We selected conditional nodes with complete numerical references and interpretable, ordered child and parent states. Binary variables qualified when their meanings supported an order; nominal variables and Boolean gate chains were excluded. The selected CPTs contain 421 rows, with at most 27 rows per node. Scrum uses an RNM-derived reference; the other BNs supply tabulated probabilities. These references represent particular modeling contexts, not universal company probabilities. The supplement describes their versions and preparation.

All RQs include every CPT row, including anchors. Single-parent and fully elicited nodes remain eligible because fitting can change their probabilities. Sampling is availability-based; the endpoint, weighting, and tests followed inspection of earlier results, making this analysis exploratory.

Table 1: LLM-assisted BN construction compared by inputs, evaluation, and scope. Entries distinguish numerical CPT agreement from modeling support and downstream performance; reported errors are not directly comparable. KL denotes Kullback–Leibler divergence.

Study	Construction and supplied evidence	Evaluation material and endpoint	Scope relative to our comparison
Nafar et al. [18] TMLR, 2026	LLM internal knowledge; one conditional row or one child-state probability per query. A separate stage combines estimates with observations.	80 public BNs, eight LLMs: BN/CPT KL. Separate classification evaluation on nine datasets with three LLMs.	Changes granularity within a row; our RNM approach requests selected rows and reconstructs the rest.
Gottal and Matthes [12] Findings ACL, 2026	Reconstruction algorithms and direct LLM CPT output from numerical statistical summaries; separate extraction from publications.	Synthetic BNs and publication/raw-data cases; CPT distances, inference and decision utility, and runtime.	Quantitative summaries constrain construction; our RAG packets supply qualitative context.
Rahul and Chowdhury [22] Preprint, 2026	Persona-conditioned LLM panels provide distributions for parent configurations; trimmed-mean aggregation.	One healthcare-consultation BN; plausibility and internal consistency checks; calls, token estimates, and runtime.	Demonstrates construction feasibility and effort; lacks an independent numerical CPT benchmark.
Feng et al. (BIRD) [9] ICLR, 2025	LLM-generated factors and coarse likelihood judgments feed constrained parameter fitting and BN inference.	Human judgments of relative support and downstream task accuracy.	Establishes a precedent for LLM judgments plus fitting; does not test numerical reference-CPT recovery.
Cypko et al. [6] IJCARS, 2026	Clinical RAG supports expert BN modeling using guidelines and textbooks.	Synthetic retrieval evaluation; modeling, usability, and workload study with four clinicians.	Tests modeling support rather than complete numerical CPT agreement.
This study	Complete CPT elicitation versus LLM anchors plus RNM fitting; baseline/structured prompts, with/without qualitative RAG.	61 ordinal conditional nodes from seven SE BNs; complete-table distances, five replications, tokens, and fitting time.	Compares final CPTs on all rows of all nodes; checks weighting sensitivity and uses anchor fitting as a diagnostic.

Table 2: Evaluated BNs and CPTs. Rows count conditional distributions across the selected nodes; anchors are the subset requested in each RNM condition. Counts are per replication and prompt/evidence combination.

BN and source	Nodes	CPT rows	Anchors
Scrum [19]	25	249	123
Chrome 40 [14]	15	78	57
Chrome 42 [14]	12	63	46
APS [13]	3	8	8
SESSI [16]	1	3	3
Software logs 3 [8]	4	16	12
Software logs 4 [8]	1	4	3
Total	61	421	252

3.2 Inputs and outputs in the eight conditions

Common inputs. Requests supplied an expert role, SE setting, variable definitions, ordered states, assumed parent influence directions, and configurations to evaluate. Answers conditioned on all listed parents and averaged over unspecified circumstances. Graphs, definitions, prompts, and numerical procedures were fixed before collection.

Methods and simplified prompts. Cohesion depends on Self-Organizing and Collaboration; all use Low, Medium, and High states. Its brief describes synchronous work toward shared goals, adapting work, and mutual support. These simplified excerpts illustrate the method-specific requests:

> **Direct:** Estimate probabilities for Low, Medium, and High Cohesion given each listed combination of Self-Organizing and Collaboration. Return all nine distributions in JSON, preserving state order and normalization.
> **RNM:** Return only the five listed anchor distributions. Select a weighted-mean, weighted-minimum, weighted-maximum, or minimum–maximum rule. Do not supply weights, variance, or other rows; these will be fitted offline.

Both methods supplied normalized vectors and an evidence note. Only RNM enforced the shared influence assumptions mathematically. Complete prompts and schemas are in the replication package.

Prompt and evidence additions. Each method used baseline/no-RAG, structured/no-RAG, baseline/RAG, and structured/RAG, yielding eight conditions. Baseline prompts requested the distributions directly. Structured prompts added the following guidance, simplified here:

> For each requested configuration, consider 100 hypothetical comparable cases. Estimate the child given the parents, distinguish evidence from assumptions, and check that probabilities sum to one.

The hypothetical cases supplied no observations; fractional expected counts were allowed. RAG added qualitative evidence cards

to either prompt style. These additions changed elicitation support, not the requested rows or output format.

RAG supplied fixed, curated paraphrases of domain explanations. Retrieval matched cards to model context and target/parent tags, selecting up to three; packets contained 24–103 words (median 72). Cohesion received cards on shared goals, organizing work, and knowledge coverage. The first card read:

> **Shared goals.** Cohesive teamwork includes commitment to shared tasks and team goals. Agile collaboration involves joint responsibility, rather than treating every task as an isolated individual obligation.

The other cards linked adapting work and overlapping expertise to flexibility. None supplied conditional frequencies: probabilities remained subjective. No-RAG requests retained the definitions without cards. Packets were reused across methods, prompt styles, and replications, excluding reference probabilities, parameters, and identifying links. RAG tested qualitative context, not live retrieval or company measurements; input budgets were not equalized.

3.3 Producing comparable complete tables

Direct outputs were complete CPTs. RNM fitted weights and variance to the selected rule and anchor distributions, then generated all rows [11, 15]. It minimized mean anchor TV without accessing reference probabilities; valid poor fits were retained. Equations, numerical settings, and influence-direction evidence appear in the supplement.

Anchors comprised all-low, all-high, all-middle, one-high/rest-low, and one-low/rest-high configurations, with duplicates removed independently of the reference. For Cohesion, RNM requests five distributions: $(0,0)$, $(2,2)$, $(1,1)$, $(2,0)$, and $(0,2)$, where 0, 1, and 2 denote ordered states. Both methods produce nine rows, all compared against the reference, including fitted anchors.

3.4 Execution and reference isolation

Five replications were collected on 15–16 October 2026 using Codex CLI 0.162.1, requesting `gpt-6-astra` at `medium` effort. Each target–condition–replication used a fresh session; requests were shuffled within replications. Temperature and generation seed were unspecified. Experimental sessions could not access references, full papers, evaluator code, or authoring conversations; tools, browsing, connectors, and memory were disabled.

Outputs required correct rows/states, finite probabilities in $[0,1]$, and sums within 10^{-6} of one. One fresh-session format repair was allowed without reference feedback. All 2,440 trials produced valid outputs after four repairs (two per method); accounting includes all 2,444 attempts, with no fallback distributions.

3.5 Outcomes and analysis

For reference row p and prediction q, lower total variation means closer agreement:

$$\mathrm{TV}(p,q) = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_s |p_s - q_s| \in [0,1]. \quad (1)$$

We average TV over rows within each node, then give all 61 nodes equal weight, preventing larger CPTs from dominating. Within each replication, RQ1 averages RNM-minus-direct differences over four prompt/evidence combinations. RQ2 contrasts structured minus baseline and RAG minus no RAG within each method, averaging the other factor. All conditions use complete tables.

Scrum and Chrome supply 52 of 61 nodes, dominating the node-weighted mean. A sensitivity analysis gives each of the five publication families equal weight, averaging nodes within BNs and BNs within families. We also report each BN descriptively. Supplementary Jensen–Shannon divergence, ordinal-CDF distance, and smoothed CPT KL use the same weights.

RQ3 counts requested distributions before repairs and client-reported tokens over all attempts for the full sample. Total tokens equal input plus output; cached-input and reasoning-output counters are subsets, not additional tokens. Paired contrasts use replication totals. Latency and offline fitting time are descriptive; subscription tokens are not converted into monetary savings.

The five paired replication blocks are the inferential units, not correlated nodes or rows. Two-sided paired t-tests ($df = 4$) and pointwise 95% intervals assume approximately normal, independent, stationary block differences. Five blocks provide little evidence for these assumptions. Two-sided exact sign tests assess direction/median sensitivity under independence; five concordant nonzero differences still yield $p = 0.0625$. Holm adjustments cover two RQ1 weighting contrasts, eight RQ2 contrasts (two methods, two factors, two weighting rules), and two RQ3 token contrasts. These are separate exploratory families, not study-wide confirmatory control; intervals are not simultaneous. No prespecified practical-effect or equivalence margin supports claims of usefulness or equivalence.

3.6 Offline diagnostics

Supplementary diagnostics examine anchor fitting, alternative functions, numerical settings, and baselines. Reference-informed fits assess best-found approximation, not error floors. Historical non-anchor, Chrome-version, and node-omission analyses concern a 25-node subset; they do not replace the full-sample endpoint or predictions.

4 Results

We first compare the accuracy of the completed CPTs (RQ1), then ask whether prompting and RAG improve that accuracy (RQ2), and finally examine the effort saved by eliciting fewer rows (RQ3). All main results include every row of all 61 nodes. Lower TV means closer reference agreement; negative RNM-minus-direct differences favor RNM.

4.1 RQ1: Which method produces closer complete CPTs?

Direct elicitation is closer overall. Mean TV is 0.2317 for direct elicitation and 0.2404 for RNM, averaging each method's four prompt/evidence combinations and five replications. RNM increases error by 0.0087, or 3.76%. Figure 1b shows all five equal-node differences to the right of zero (0.0072–0.0094), indicating higher RNM error. The diamond and whiskers show the mean and its pointwise 95% t interval, $[0.0076, 0.0098]$. The Holm-adjusted paired-t test rejects ($p = 0.000048$), but the exact sign test does not ($p = 0.125$). The

Table 3: Complete-table TV by BN, averaged over prompt/evidence conditions and replications. Δ is RNM minus direct. Every node is included; BN rows are descriptive.

BN	Nodes	Direct	RNM	Δ
Scrum	25	0.2605	0.2334	−0.0272
Chrome 40	15	0.2069	0.2220	+0.0151
Chrome 42	12	0.1988	0.2335	+0.0347
APS	3	0.0964	0.1155	+0.0191
SESSI	1	0.1160	0.1143	−0.0017
Software logs 3	4	0.3802	0.4770	+0.0967
Software logs 4	1	0.2052	0.3299	+0.1247
All nodes	61	0.2317	0.2404	+0.0087

direction is consistent across runs, with limited distribution-free evidence; neither test establishes practical importance.

Scrum and Chrome supply 52 of 61 nodes. Figure 1b therefore also gives each source study equal weight. Direct elicitation still has lower TV: 0.1937 versus 0.2189, a difference of 0.0252 (12.99%), with interval $[0.0211, 0.0292]$, adjusted t $p = 0.000065$, and adjusted sign $p = 0.125$. Reducing the influence of larger studies retains the conclusion. Secondary complete-table distances agree under both weights (supplement).

The overall result masks unequal gains and losses. Table 3 gives each BN's mean errors; its Δ column and Figure 1a show their direction and magnitude. Scrum improves from 0.2605 to 0.2334, and SESSI improves slightly. Both Chrome versions, APS, and both log BNs worsen, with the largest increases in the five log nodes. RNM nevertheless wins on 31 of 61 individual nodes. Larger deteriorations outweigh those gains: the aggregate compares error magnitudes, not win counts. BN-level contrasts are descriptive, not seven separate population effects.

Two rows make the differences concrete. Figure 2 compares probability allocations for two configurations not queried by RNM. In panel (a), a Scrum team has Low Self-Organizing but Medium Collaboration. The reference assigns 76.6% probability to Low Cohesion. Direct elicitation assigns 58.0%; RNM assigns 67.6%, closer to the reference. Mean row TV falls from 0.1862 to 0.0901. Thus reconstruction can improve agreement beyond the elicited anchors.

Panel (b) shows a different outcome. A Chrome component has three or four contributors and no minor contributors. Contributors are classified by their share of changes, so all must be major: the Major Contributors node belongs in the three-to-four category. The reference and all direct responses assign probability one there. RNM assigns 84.4%, spreading 15.6% into neighboring categories. Its reconstruction weakens a count constraint preserved by direct elicitation. These selected examples explain opposing effects without establishing their prevalence across the sample.

Supplementary diagnostics on identical anchors in the 25-node compression subset show little change from fitting for Scrum (TV 0.2790 to 0.2762), but deterioration for Chrome (0.2491 to 0.2994). Alternative functions, searches, and reference-informed fits explore that contrast without establishing a single cause of the full-sample result. **RQ1 favors direct elicitation on average under both weighting rules, despite RNM gains in some nodes and BNs.**

Table 4: All eight conditions: complete-table TV across all 61 nodes, with equal node weights and five replications. Each row pairs the methods under the same prompt and evidence.

Prompt	Evidence	Direct	RNM	Δ
Baseline	None	0.2327	0.2396	+0.0070
Baseline	RAG	0.2349	0.2419	+0.0070
Structured	None	0.2282	0.2389	+0.0107
Structured	RAG	0.2311	0.2413	+0.0102

4.2 RQ2: Do richer prompts or qualitative evidence help?

Structured prompting offers a limited benefit. Table 4 pairs the methods under identical support. Read across rows to compare direct and RNM, and down each method's column to compare prompts and evidence. Every Δ is positive: direct elicitation remains closer in all four pairs. Its lowest mean TV, 0.2282, occurs with structured prompts and no RAG.

Averaging over evidence conditions, structured prompting lowers direct TV by 0.00413 (interval $[-0.00595, -0.00232]$, Holm-adjusted t $p = 0.0255$). This is the only RQ2 contrast that rejects after eight-test correction. Equal-family weighting gives a similar direction (−0.00508) but an interval crossing zero and adjusted $p = 0.4953$. No RQ2 exact sign test rejects. For RNM, the prompt effect is only −0.00067 and does not reject after adjustment.

Qualitative RAG provides no demonstrated gain. Adding RAG raises mean error under both prompt styles in Table 4. Averaged over styles, the change is +0.00252 for direct elicitation and +0.00230 for RNM; neither adjusted test rejects. The Cohesion card illustrates the information provided: shared goals and joint responsibility, without conditional frequencies. **RQ2 supports structured direct elicitation only under node weighting and demonstrates no benefit from this qualitative RAG.** This does not establish equivalence or rule out benefits from local quantitative evidence. Full contrasts appear in the supplement.

4.3 RQ3: Do fewer judgments translate into fewer tokens?

Elicitation shrinks more than token usage. RNM requests 5,040 distributions versus 8,420 for direct elicitation: 40.1% fewer. Both still make one initial request per node and condition, carrying shared instructions, definitions, and evidence. Table 5 separates generated output from the whole exchange. Output tokens fall by 12.12%, but total tokens fall by only 0.61%, because inputs dominate (approximately 14.36 million direct and 14.31 million RNM).

Across five paired replication totals, the adjusted t test supports output savings ($p = 0.000073$), but not total-token savings ($p = 0.0809$); both adjusted exact sign tests give $p = 0.125$. The supplement reports block differences and intervals. Fewer requested probabilities therefore do not produce proportional token savings.

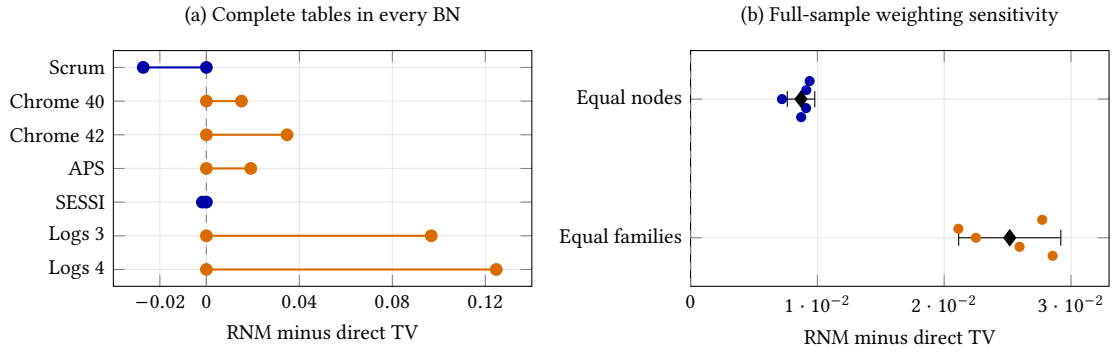


Figure 1: Complete-CPT agreement across the full sample. Negative differences favor RNM. (a) Each BN's mean averages all rows within nodes, then nodes, four prompt/evidence combinations, and five replications equally; points are descriptive. (b) Both weighting rules retain all 61 nodes. Circles show the five block differences; diamonds and whiskers show means and pointwise 95% t intervals. Equal-family weighting first averages nodes within BNs and BNs within each of five publication families.

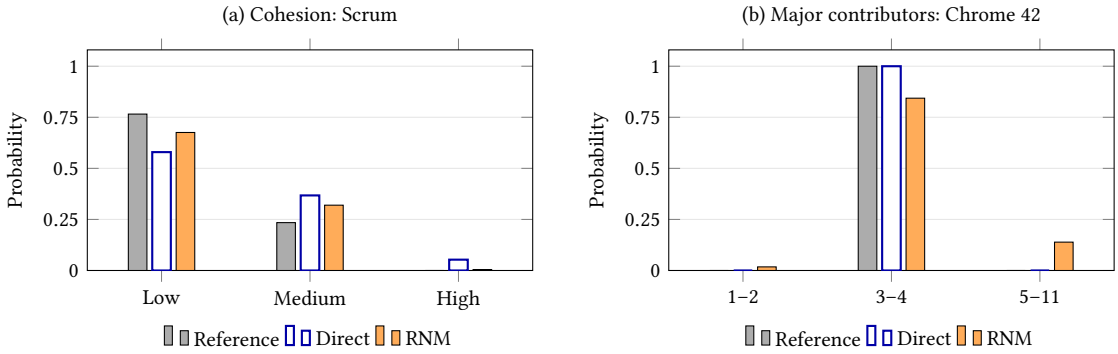


Figure 2: Two CPT rows unqueried by RNM. (a) Cohesion given Low Self-Organizing and Medium Collaboration. (b) Major contributors given three or four total contributors and no minor contributors. Bars average 20 predictions per method. Examples were selected for opposing effects in the earlier non-anchor comparison; they illustrate mechanisms and do not represent the full sample.

Table 5: RQ3: tokens across all 61 nodes and five replications, including repairs. Holm-adjusted paired-t tests compare five method-paired block totals across two counters; neither exact sign test rejects.

Counter	Direct	RNM	Reduction	Holm t p
Output	341,153	299,798	12.12%	0.000073
Input + output	14,697,090	14,607,517	0.61%	0.080921

The savings do not establish a better overall trade-off. Summed request latency is 3.82% lower for RNM; the original retained fits sum to 182.3 seconds of recorded fitting time, excluding subsequent offline diagnostics. These are computational descriptions, not controlled wall-clock or monetary savings. **RQ3 supports reduced elicitation and output size, with limited evidence of total-token savings.** Those savings accompany higher mean complete-table error across the sample, so they do not establish a superior accuracy–effort tradeoff.

5 Discussion

The three RQs distinguish reference agreement, the effects of elicitation support, and token usage. Together, they inform the selection and validation of a CPT construction pipeline rather than identify a universally preferable method.

5.1 Research questions in relation to the literature

RQ1: Reconstruction is an assumption, not an accuracy guarantee. RNM imposes a shared mathematical relationship across rows [11,

15]. This can stabilize uncertain judgments, but also spread error when the intended relationship differs. Scrum's RNM-derived reference makes compatibility plausible; Chrome's contributor-count example exposes a constraint that smoothing weakens. Restricted diagnostics support compatibility as an explanation, without isolating it from influence assumptions, LLM judgments, or optimization. The other BNs show why this interpretation cannot be reduced to a Scrum–Chrome dichotomy.

Blomaard et al. fit semi-automatic methods against known CPTs [2], examining what their representations can approximate. Our fits use uncertain LLM judgments, testing the whole pipeline. Nafar et al.'s gains from finer probability-query granularity [18] concern asking smaller questions, rather than omitting configurations. These comparisons distinguish elicitation quality from reconstruction compatibility: ordinal states make RNM applicable, but do not establish its suitability for every relationship.

RQ2: Instructions and evidence address different problems. Structured prompts clarify conditioning and normalization without supplying missing domain knowledge. Their limited benefit for direct elicitation is consistent with that distinction, although our design does not isolate which instruction helped. For RNM, improved judgments must also survive fitting. Weighting-sensitive findings do not establish a general prompting advantage across SE contexts.

Qualitative RAG reinforces meanings and relationships already partly expressed in the common brief; it cannot uniquely determine conditional frequencies. Gottal and Matthes instead use numerical summaries to constrain reconstruction [12], while Cypko et al. assess clinical modeling support [6]. Our result concerns numerical agreement under a particular evidence design, not RAG's value for modeling assistance. Whether company measurements improve elicitation remains untested.

RQ3: Human burden and token usage are different resources. Partial elicitation reduces the judgments experts must supply [1]. In an LLM workflow, repeated definitions and instructions can dominate the tokens used to return probabilities. Output compression therefore need not yield comparable total-token savings. Alternative batching or context reuse would require a new controlled comparison that also checks accuracy; our token totals establish neither monetary nor computational savings.

5.2 Implications for SE researchers and practitioners

For researchers. Evaluate complete CPTs alongside diagnostics separating raw judgments from fitting effects. Report aggregate error and variation across BNs: conclusions can depend on study representation or large deteriorations despite many small gains. Match the endpoint to the claim. BIRD evaluates LLM judgments coupled with BN inference [9]; similarly, SE studies should test whether CPT differences change release, prioritization, or process-improvement decisions. Reference agreement alone cannot demonstrate decision value or explainability.

For practitioners. Use direct elicitation as the initial numerical baseline suggested by this sample; consider RNM when its compensatory or constraining relationships match domain knowledge. Check logical constraints before accepting smooth distributions: contributor counts can exclude otherwise plausible states. Treat either output as a candidate requiring review. Generic definitions and reusable BN components can initialize a model, but organization-specific probabilities require local evidence and validation. Experts could focus on consequential or uncertain relationships, supported by sensitivity analysis and held-out company cases. This is a proposed validation strategy, not evidence that limited expert input necessarily suffices.

6 Threats to Validity

Construct validity. TV measures reference agreement, not company outcomes; equal-row scoring gives rare and common configurations equal influence. Complete-table evaluation and supplementary distances check sensitivity to the endpoint, but cannot establish calibration, explanation quality, or decision utility. RQ1 therefore compares numerical outputs, not expert replacement. No acceptable-error margin establishes practical sufficiency.

Reference validity. Scrum's RNM-derived reference may favor RNM; prompt and fitting development also used that setting. SESSI represents an original elicitation stage. We checked dimensions, normalization, and indexing and reported BN-specific results and fitting diagnostics. These cannot certify Scrum against an independent AgenaRisk export. Shared definitions control presentation, not the correctness of adapted meanings or uncertain influence directions. Cross-BN differences therefore admit multiple explanations.

Internal validity. Fresh sessions, disabled tools, withheld references, and reference-blind fitting limited direct access, not public-BN memorization. Logs record requested settings, not an independently verified serving version. Schema checks and format repairs ensure valid distributions, not semantic fidelity; exhaustive human review was absent. Alternative fits checked sensitivity, but bounded searches can miss better fits and reference-informed diagnostics are optimistic. RQ2 evaluates bundles, preventing attribution to individual instructions or cards.

Conclusion validity. We paired replication blocks rather than treating correlated nodes or rows as independent, reported intervals, and combined Holm-adjusted tests with exact-sign sensitivity checks. Five blocks permit weak checks of normality, independence, and stationarity; conflicting tests limit confidence. The SE restriction, complete-table endpoint, weighting, and tests followed earlier result inspection, making inference exploratory. Separate Holm families do not provide study-wide confirmatory control; non-rejection does not establish equivalence.

External validity. The sample spans five publication families; Scrum and Chrome supply 52 of 61 nodes. Equal-family weighting checks their influence without making the sample representative. CPTs have at most 27 rows; some allow no elicitation reduction. We tested only GPT-6 Astra at medium effort and qualitative evidence. RQ3 includes repair tokens but cannot predict other implementations' costs. Larger CPTs, other models, and local numerical evidence require validation.

7 Conclusion

Requesting fewer probabilities from an LLM does not by itself improve the completed CPT. Across 61 ordinal nodes from seven SE BNs, direct elicitation provided the stronger average numerical baseline, while RNM helped some relationships and weakened others. Structured prompting offered limited support, and qualitative RAG added no demonstrated benefit beyond common definitions. Smaller RNM outputs also yielded little reduction in total tokens. The lesson is to evaluate the completed table and full interaction before equating fewer judgments with better or cheaper modeling.

Our contribution is a controlled comparison of complete construction pipelines, including anchors, systematically varying prompting and evidence. Network-level results, weighting sensitivity, and fitting diagnostics distinguish the overall tendency from variation between relationships. This exploratory benchmark does not establish deployment readiness; five replications and sensitivity to the statistical test limit inferential strength.

The next priority is to test whether organization-specific measurements and targeted expert review improve candidate CPTs and their decisions. Evaluation should measure calibration and decision quality on held-out company cases. A complementary direction is to select direct elicitation or RNM by relationship, using constraints and compatibility checks established without test references. Additional models, larger CPTs, and controlled context reuse would test whether the accuracy–effort trade-off changes. This would move from generating plausible tables toward demonstrating their value for SE decision support.

Data Availability Statement

The anonymous replication package provides prompts, reference CPTs, responses, fitted tables, evaluation code, token counts, and supplementary analyses: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/llm-rnm-se-replication-13FA.

Use of AI Statement

GPT-6 Astra generated experimental judgments (Section 3). OpenAI Codex assisted study preparation, coding, analysis, and writing; Elicit supported literature discovery. Scores trace to saved responses and evaluation code. Authors retain responsibility for all content.

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